Cryptic genomic variation in a panmictic squid: an ancient inversion supergene and genome-wide signatures of positive selection in *Illex illecebrosus*

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Draft November 13, 2026

Author input needed (remove before submission).

1. Introduction, second paragraph, "(needs reference)": large-N_e terrestrial species without geographic structure (review minor 2).
2. Citation for the 51 Myr divergence and 46% alignment rate (minor 4), and for bgspy (text names it, no bib or Table S10 entry).
3. False-discovery rate of the 11 background-selection-robust regions (minor 27), needs the circular-shift null rerun with the BGS test.
4. The ∼33% depletion of near-fixed differences in the outermost megabase has no supporting figure (minor 14).
5. Stairway Plot 2 dip at 1,200–3,000 generations is not tested (minor 20).
6. Archived versioned releases (Zenodo DOIs) of the manuscript repository, msinv, pg_gpu and degenotate (minor 65, M10), data accessions, Table S10 gaps, funding and contributions, "Draft November 13, 2026".
7. Major comments M1–M3, M5, M7 (supergene/ancient wording, power simulation), M8, M9 (one $N_{e,Z}$).

Abstract

Marine species with high dispersal capabilities often exhibit minimal geographic population structure while maintaining significant adaptive genomic variation. In this study, we employ a chromosome-level reference genome and whole-genome data from 618 northern shortfin squid, *Illex illecebrosus*, collected across the Northwest Atlantic, to elucidate genomic variation previously inaccessible with a divergent reference assembly. Our findings confirm nearly complete range-wide panmixia, yet reveal a single major axis of genomic structure, a ∼19 Mb inversion on chromosome 2. Its derived arrangement segregates at a frequency of 0.601, is present throughout the species' range without a geographic cline, and achieves $F_{ST} = 0.36$ between alternative homozygotes despite a geographic $F_{ST} \approx 0$. Its evolutionary trajectory is inconsistent with neutral drift. The common derived arrangement retains 2.1 times less diversity than expected given its current frequency, and approximate Bayesian computation with a barrier-aware coalescent simulator favours balancing selection over neutral drift and directional selection. Neural

posterior estimation places the formation of the recombination barrier about 390 ka, and the derived arrangement began to rise from a founding frequency near 0.05 about 310 ka towards an equilibrium near 0.60, at which it has since been held. The inversion is gene-poor and lacks functional enrichment, yet contains thousands of near-fixed differences concentrated within the non-recombining block, suggesting selection on the arrangement as a long-lived supergene rather than on a single locally adaptive locus. Outside the inversion, demographic analyses indicate strong expansion (genome-wide Tajima's $D \approx -2$) to a current effective population size of approximately seven million. A stratified scan, corroborated across methods, for recent positive selection identified 627 candidate sweep calls, including 24 high-confidence regions independently supported by multiple methods. Genes associated with these sweeps show significant enrichment for neurodevelopment and photoreception, with additional candidates involving lineage-specific genes and Z-linked RNA-regulatory and hormone-signaling loci. In males, linkage disequilibrium decays at the same rate on the Z chromosome as on the autosomes, which, after accounting for a female mutation rate two to four times the male rate, is consistent with achiasmate female meiosis, as in octopuses. Collectively, these findings reveal two contrasting modes of adaptation in an otherwise panmictic marine species, a long-lived chromosomal polymorphism whose derived arrangement is held by balancing selection at an intermediate frequency, and recent directional selection on sensory and neural functions. More broadly, they illustrate how a conspecific reference genome can uncover structural and adaptive variation that remains largely undetectable through geographic differentiation alone.

1 Introduction

Population genetic theory predicts that species with vast census sizes and high dispersal will show weak geographic differentiation, because migration homogenizes allele frequencies faster than drift can differentiate them, and a large effective size makes selection efficient while further slowing drift. There are examples of large-N_e species with no geographic structure in terrestrial systems (needs reference), but the pattern is less well characterized in marine species, where high gene flow leaves weak differentiation that is difficult to distinguish from sampling noise with few markers (Waples, 1998; Hauser and Carvalho, 2008; Gagnaire et al., 2015). More broadly, genomic analysis of cephalopods has lagged behind that of many commercially important vertebrates due to their large, repeat-rich, and extensively reorganized genomes relative to other molluscs (Albertin et al., 2015, 2022; Schmidbaur et al., 2022; Coffing et al., 2025, 2026; Small et al., 2026). Until recently, these limitations were particularly pronounced for *Illex illecebrosus*, as no conspecific chromosome-level reference genome was available.

Pelagic cephalopods exemplify a marine system where we might expect large N_e and low geographic differentiation. Ommastrephid squids, which are short-lived, semelparous, highly fecund, and capable of extensive dispersal during both early life stages and adulthood, generate large and often highly variable populations whose abundance is closely linked to oceanographic conditions (O'Dor and Dawe, 1998; Arkhipkin et al., 2015). The northern shortfin squid, *Illex illecebrosus*, exemplifies this life history. It is an annual semelparous broadcast spawner distributed over more than 2,500 km of the Northwest Atlantic shelf and slope, from the Mid-Atlantic Bight to Newfoundland and Labrador, where it supports major commercial fisheries in both U.S. and Canadian waters (O'Dor and Dawe, 1998; Arkhipkin et al., 2015; Baker et al., 2025). Recruitment and distribution are strongly influenced by transport in the Gulf Stream and associated shelf and slope circulation, while adults undertake extensive horizontal and diel vertical migrations. Collectively, high dispersal, extreme fecundity, and large population size predict minimal persistent geographic structure, while providing a substantial substrate for natural selection.

The inaugural comprehensive population genomic analysis of *Illex illecebrosus* established a

crucial baseline. Utilizing whole-genome data from 540 specimens collected from over 40 locations, Baker et al. (2025) identified an absence of geographic genetic structure across the species' Northwest Atlantic range. This finding aligns with the hypothesis of extensive connectivity facilitated by early-life dispersal and adult migration, thereby supporting the classification of *Illex illecebrosus* as a single, highly interconnected stock. Nevertheless, due to the lack of a conspecific genome assembly, the reads were aligned to the chromosome-level genome of the distantly related diamondback squid, *Thysanoteuthis rhombus*, which diverged approximately 51 million years ago, resulting in a mean alignment rate of merely ∼46%. This divergence inherently limits inference to the conserved genome fraction that can be reliably mapped, thereby diminishing the ability to detect lineage-specific sequences, structural polymorphisms, and rapidly evolving loci. Reference divergence matters most for inversions. Detecting an inversion requires mapping both its breakpoints and the long differentiated haplotypes between them, and both are lost where reads map poorly, so a population studied against a distant reference can appear to lack inversions it actually carries. Consistent with this, Baker et al. (2025) did not find evidence of large structural variants and cautioned that remapping could reveal signals in genomic regions that are not conserved between the two families.

Chromosomal inversions are a prime example of such variation. Inversions inhibit recombination between alternative arrangements, thereby maintaining combinations of alleles as segregating "supergenes" (Kirkpatrick, 2010; Schwander et al., 2014; Thompson and Jiggins, 2014; Wellenreuther and Bernatchez, 2018; Faria et al., 2019), and their evolutionary significance arises not only from their breakpoints but also from the long haplotypes they preserve. Numerous well-documented instances exhibit noticeable phenotypic effects or occur in spatially structured populations, such as mimicry in *Heliconius* (Jay et al., 2021), alternative reproductive morphs in the ruff (Lamichhaney et al., 2016), colony organization in fire ants (Wang et al., 2013), and life-history variation in *Mimulus* (Lowry and Willis, 2010). Consequently, much of the inversion theory has concentrated on local adaptation with migration, where suppressed recombination safeguards locally advantageous allele combinations from gene flow (Kirkpatrick and Barton, 2006; Charlesworth and Barton, 2018). That explanation has the least scope in a large, weakly structured population, so an inversion maintained there at intermediate frequency without geographic structuring presents a distinct challenge. Its persistence suggests balancing mechanisms such as overdominance, associative overdominance induced by recessive deleterious load (Zhao and Charlesworth, 2016; Gilbert et al., 2020; Jay et al., 2021), negative frequency dependence, or temporally fluctuating selection (Wittmann et al., 2017; Rudman et al., 2022), and because large effective size slows drift, the history of such a polymorphism can extend over hundreds of thousands of generations. Differentiating these histories from neutral drift necessitates reconstructing the age and frequency history of the arrangements while explicitly considering the recombination barrier between them (Navarro et al., 2000; Guerrero et al., 2012; Berdan et al., 2023).

A chromosome-level *Illex illecebrosus* genome facilitates the investigation of selection beyond large structural polymorphisms. Cephalopods present a unique context for this inquiry because of their extreme life history, which is associated with remarkable sensory and neural complexity. Coleoid genomes demonstrate significant lineage-specific reorganization (Schmidbaur et al., 2022), extensive RNA-editing-based transcriptomic plasticity (Liscovitch-Brauer et al., 2017), and sophisticated nervous and visual systems (Albertin et al., 2015, 2022; Styfhals et al., 2022; Songco-Casey et al., 2022). In cephalopods, vision adapts to substantial changes in depth and illumination during diel vertical migration, with photoreception extending beyond the camera eye to include dermal opsins and light-responsive chromatophore systems (Mäthger et al., 2010; Ramirez and Oakley, 2015; Kingston et al., 2015). In a large, highly connected population where geographic F_{ST} offers limited utility for detecting adaptation, recent positive selection is likely to manifest

primarily through local distortions in diversity, linkage disequilibrium, and the site-frequency spectrum. Accurate interpretation of these signals necessitates first establishing the demographic and genealogical context in which they emerged.

In this study, we employed a chromosome-level annotated reference genome for *Illex illecebrosus* (Small et al., 2026) to reanalyze range-wide whole-genome variation with a significantly enhanced genomic resolution. Our dataset included 618 individuals distributed across 11 fishery management divisions (Baker et al., 2025), along with *I. coindetii* (Genoscope, 2025) as an outgroup for divergence-based inference and *I. argentinus* as a recently diverged species. Initially, we assessed whether the range-wide panmixia reported by Baker et al. (2025) persisted when reads were aligned to a conspecific reference and investigated the emergence of previously inaccessible structural variations. This analysis identified a single ∼19 Mb inversion on chromosome 2 that segregated across the range, despite an otherwise largely unstructured genome. Subsequently, we tested whether this inversion represented a neutral polymorphism or a selected supergene by integrating arrangement-specific diversity and divergence with a barrier-aware coalescent model to reconstruct its age and historical frequency trajectories. Concurrently, we inferred population history from the site frequency spectrum and linkage disequilibrium, explicitly evaluating whether the data necessitated a sweepstakes-reproductive-success models (fecundity-with-high-mortality), wherein a small and variable fraction of adults contributes disproportionately to each generation (Hedgecock and Pudovkin, 2011; Eldon and Wakeley, 2006; Árnason et al., 2023) rather than Kingman coalescent, and scanned the remaining genome for recent positive selection using complementary methods (Kern and Schrider, 2018; Alachiotis and Pavlidis, 2018; DeGiorgio et al., 2016). These analyses elucidated two distinct forms of genomic adaptation in an otherwise panmictic species, a long-lived chromosomal polymorphism under selection and a genome-wide set of recent sweeps concentrated on neurodevelopmental and photoreceptive functions. Collectively, these studies demonstrated how a conspecific genome transformed the apparent genomic landscape of a highly connected marine species, revealing structural and adaptive variations that were largely undetectable through geographic differentiation alone.

2 Results

2.1 Sample, sex, and the absence of geographic structure

We conducted an analysis of 618 *Illex illecebrosus* individuals from eleven NAFO management divisions, covering approximately 37–50°N (fig. 1, table 1). Details of each collection event, including source and depth, are provided in Supplementary Table S1. The read coverage on the Z chromosome categorizes the sample into 341 ZZ males and 277 ZO females, aligning with a ZZ/ZO system (Coffing et al., 2025; Small et al., 2026) (fig. 2). Autosomal analyses incorporate both sexes, while the Z chromosome, where males are diploid and females are haploid, is examined separately (section 2.5).

Consistent with range-wide panmixia reported by Baker et al. (2025), population structure is observed in a specific genomic region, although it is not geographically linked. A windowed principal-component analysis along chromosome 2 identifies the three-cluster structure within the inversion (among-karyotype variance $\eta^2 = 0.87$ within the inversion compared to $\eta^2 = 0.003$ in the collinear sequence, Supplementary Fig. S1), and two genome-wide tests confirm its uniqueness. First, the chromosome-2 karyotype does not account for variation on any other chromosome (in a per-chromosome PCA colored by karyotype, $\eta^2 = 0.86$ on chr2 versus ≤ 0.01 on all 45 others). Second, independent of the chromosome-2 labels, a Gaussian-mixture screen of each chromosome's leading principal component supports discrete clusters only on chromosome 2 (three clusters,

ΔBIC = 187, cluster separation 8.5σ) and on the Z chromosome (two clusters, ΔBIC = 102, reflecting the expected ZZ/ZO hemizygosity split). Among the other autosomes a second component is favoured only on chromosomes 1 and 8 (ΔBIC = 11 and 7), whose leading axes are continuous gradients of sequencing depth (Spearman $\rho = -0.92$ and -0.93) rather than separate groups, so every other autosome forms a single cloud of points (fig. 2). The residual dispersion on the autosomal PCA axes does not correlate with division or latitude, and the leading axis tracks sequencing depth (Supplementary Fig. S2), and a KING-robust relatedness screen (Manichaikul et al., 2010) identifies no duplicate (kinship > 0.354) or first-degree pairs (0.177–0.354), with only a single second-degree pair (0.088–0.177) among the 618 individuals (kinship 0.16), indicating effective unrelatedness.

Given that a per-SNP differentiation scan is the most sensitive test for local adaptation in such a panmictic population, we compared per-SNP Hudson F_{ST} among divisions (Bhatia et al., 2013) to a permutation null, in which division labels were shuffled among individuals 20 times. This null keeps the genotype calls, missingness, allele-frequency spectrum and linkage of the data and removes only geography. Across the complete per-chromosome callsets of the 620 individuals from the ten divisions with more than one sample, which include the two excluded after the scan, we evaluated every biallelic SNP with a minor-allele frequency above 0.05 (20,117,984 SNPs on the 45 autosomes, Supplementary Methods), and the empirical differentiation remains entirely within the null expectation. No SNP surpasses the permutation maximum, and the number of SNPs above each upper null percentile lies within the range of the permutations (2,319 of the autosomal SNPs outside the inversion above the 99.99th percentile against $1{,}998 \pm 352$, permutation $p = 0.24$), including within the chromosome-2 inversion (8 against 13 expected), so the upper tail holds no more candidates than chance (Supplementary Figs. S3, S4). Nucleotide diversity and Tajima's D are consistent across latitude, and pairwise F_{ST} among divisions is approximately 0 throughout (fig. 6). Consequently, we find no evidence of geographic local adaptation anywhere in the genome, and the inversion itself is geographically non-clinal (fig. 1, Supplementary Fig. S5 and Table S2).

Furthermore, arrangement frequency does not correlate with capture depth, which ranges from 3 to 613 m across collection events (Supplementary Table S1). Among 536 individuals with recorded depth, the correlation between depth and the number of 2+ chromosomes carried is $\rho = -0.06$ ($p = 0.20$), and within the six divisions sampled at multiple depths, it is $\rho = +0.03$ (within-division permutation $p = 0.68$). Across collection events, the slope of 2+ frequency on depth is not significant (weighted least squares over the 11 events with at least five individuals, $p = 0.09$).

2.2 A large, selected inversion on chromosome 2

Identity, breakpoints, and karyotypes. Local PCA (Li and Ralph, 2019) and a Gaussian-mixture karyotype assignment (99.7% concordant with a depth-equalised recall) resolve three genotype clusters on chromosome 2, the karyotypes of two arrangements that we call 2a and 2+ (2a/2a $n = 222$, 2a/2+ $n = 299$ and 2+/2+ $n = 97$, fig. 3a), whose differentiation is karyotypic rather than geographic, with $F_{ST} = 0.36$ between 2a/2a and 2+/2+ over the inversion as a whole (Hudson ratio of averages between the breakpoints, chr2:60.54–79.50 Mb) against a geographic $F_{ST} \approx 0$. In 100-kb windows along the whole chromosome, between-karyotype F_{ST} is ≈ 0 across collinear sequence (median 0.006) and rises to a median of 0.36 (maximum 0.56) inside the inversion (Supplementary Fig. S6), so the karyotypes are one panmictic population everywhere except within the barrier. The karyotype groups do not differ in sequencing depth, call rate or sampling division, and the diversity ratio between arrangements is unchanged with groups matched on depth or estimated from genotype likelihoods (Supplementary Methods). The three karyotypes co-occur throughout the range with no latitudinal cline in arrangement frequency (derived-arrangement frequency 0.50–0.70 across divisions, fig. 1, Supplementary Fig. S5 and Table S2). Two independent

lines pin the breakpoints to chr2:60.54–79.50 Mb (a ∼18.96 Mb inversion), namely a step-change in arrangement differentiation and a strand flip in a whole-chromosome alignment to *I. coindetii* (Supplementary Fig. S7), and an extended block of linkage disequilibrium coincides with the same interval (Supplementary Fig. S8).

The reference individual carries both arrangements. We treat 2a, at a present frequency of 0.601, as the derived arrangement and 2+, at 0.398, as the ancestral arrangement. The reference allele cannot polarize the arrangements, because the individual from which the reference was assembled is heterozygous for the inversion. Its two haplotype assemblies differ by an inversion at 60.54–79.53 Mb, matching the breakpoints inferred from the population data, the haplotype inverted relative to the primary assembly carrying 2a and the other, like the primary assembly, carrying 2+ (Supplementary Table S3). Whole-chromosome alignment of both haplotypes to *I. coindetii* shows that chromosome 2 is extensively rearranged between the species, with large blocks translocated and inverted along its length, and the inversion region is part of this complex structure. A 37-Mb segment of the *I. coindetii* chromosome (37.95–74.95 Mb) aligns to 2+ as one contiguous run, inverted as a whole, spanning 35.1 Mb of chr2 (44.4–79.5 Mb), so 2+ keeps the *I. coindetii* order within the segment. In 2a the right part of the run, the segregating inversion, is inverted a second time, which breaks the *I. coindetii* adjacency at the left breakpoint. Arrangement 2+ therefore differs from *I. coindetii* across this segment by one inversion and 2a by two, which places 2a as derived. The segregating inversion shares its right breakpoint with the older inverted block, so this region has rearranged repeatedly. Because *I. coindetii* cannot polarize that shared right breakpoint, we also aligned both haplotypes to the more distant *Sthenoteuthis oualaniensis* (Li et al., 2022), a member of the same family whose chromosome 2 is rearranged throughout relative to *Illex illecebrosus*. Both inversion breakpoints lie inside collinear blocks of its chromosome, and at each breakpoint it keeps the 2+ adjacency and lacks the 2a adjacency, so it also places 2a as derived (Supplementary Table S3). The trajectory models fitted below follow the frequency of 2a as the derived arrangement.

The inversion is non-neutral. The primary evidence is per-arrangement diversity (table 2, fig. 3c). Inside an inversion the two arrangements behave as partially isolated demes (Navarro et al., 2000; Guerrero et al., 2012), and without gene flux between them the neutral diversity of each scales with its frequency (Navarro et al., 2000). The common derived arrangement is instead less diverse than its frequency predicts, with $\pi_I/\pi_S = 0.719 \pm 0.027$ (ratio of summed π over the 189 differentiated 100-kb windows of the inversion, ± standard error from a delete-one jackknife over 1-Mb blocks) against an equilibrium expectation of $p/(1-p) = 1.51$ for a polymorphism held at 0.601, a 2.1-fold deficit. Diversity within an arrangement approaches this equilibrium only over a time of the order of the arrangement's own effective size, so the deficit is the signature of an arrangement that became common recently on that time scale. Model choice among neutral drift, directional selection and balancing selection excludes neutral drift as the cause (next paragraph).

Age and trajectory of the inversion. Estimating an inversion's age requires a simulation in which the two arrangements exchange ancestry everywhere except across the inversion, where they exchange it only by gene flux. Standard coalescent simulators do not provide this barrier, so we simulated the inversion with msinv (Small, 2025), a sequentially Markov coalescent simulator with recombination that enforces the recombination barrier between arrangements, tracks ancestral material, and outputs tree sequences (section 6). We compared four histories of the frequency of 2a by approximate Bayesian computation (ABC). Under neutral drift (N), 2a drifts from its founding.

Under directional selection it rises toward fixation and is caught on the way, either still rising (D1) or after selection stopped (D2). Under balancing selection (B) it is drawn toward an equilibrium frequency p^*. Each history starts either from a single copy or from a founding frequency p_0, and gene flux between the arrangements is allowed. The comparison used 39 statistics of the inversion, namely the ratios of within-arrangement diversity, divergence and singleton fraction, the site-frequency spectrum of each arrangement, the joint spectrum between arrangements, and linkage disequilibrium by distance in each arrangement (Supplementary Methods). Parameters of the favoured model were then estimated by neural posterior estimation (NPE) (Cranmer et al., 2020; Min et al., 2026), which learns the joint posterior from simulations drawn from the prior and can be checked for calibration on held-out simulations. The neutral baseline for these simulations was fitted to collinear chromosome-2 sequence flanking the inversion (chr2:40–55 and 85–115 Mb, Supplementary Methods), which is less diverse ($\pi = 0.0061$) than the autosomes as a whole.

Model choice among the four histories with gene flux, by ABC with random forests (ABC-RF) (Pudlo et al., 2016) on a reference table of 16,959 simulations, favours balancing selection, with a posterior probability of 0.83 against 0.04–0.08 for each of the others (Supplementary Methods). Most of this support comes from how readily each history reaches the present frequency. Paths under balancing selection end within the accepted window about 12 times as often as paths under the other histories, because any p^* near 0.602 holds 2a there whereas a sweep must be caught mid-course. The summary statistics alone separate the four histories only weakly (cross-validated accuracy 0.51, Supplementary Fig. S9). Under balancing selection, a start from a single copy carries 3% of the posterior mass. Under the favoured model with gene flux, the NPE posterior (table 2, fig. 4b) places the formation of the recombination barrier about 390 ka (95% credible interval 260–720 ka). 2a began to rise from a founding frequency of about 0.05 (0.004–0.10) about 310 ka (190–520 ka) and has been held near its equilibrium, $p^* = 0.603$ (0.575–0.707), since. Half of the trajectories re-simulated from the posterior reach a frequency of 0.55 within about 6,000 generations of the onset, and the slowest fifth, mostly those with $s < 10^{-4}$, take more than 50,000 generations. The selection coefficient has only a lower bound (95% of the posterior above 2.1×10^{-5} and 80% above 10^{-4}), because any stronger selection reaches the equilibrium quickly and leaves the same present-day statistics. The fitted gene-flux rate is 3.9×10^{-7} (4×10^{-9} to 6.1×10^{-7}) per site per generation in heterokaryotypes. The joint posterior (Supplementary Fig. S10) shows the barrier age rising with the gene-flux rate (Spearman $\rho = 0.62$) and with the onset of selection ($\rho = 0.56$), whereas the selection coefficient is unrelated to the founding frequency ($\rho = -0.11$). The NPE posterior is calibrated, with 95% credible intervals containing the true value in 94–96% of 2,000 held-out simulations for every parameter, and the observed statistics lie well inside the simulations it was trained on (Supplementary Methods). Without gene flux the barrier is younger (280 ka, 220–360 ka) and the founding frequency similar (0.03). Posterior predictive simulations of the favoured model from 1,000 NPE posterior draws reproduce the data (joint posterior predictive $p = 0.51$, Supplementary Fig. S11), including three statistics withheld from the fit, the Tajima's D of each arrangement and the ratio of divergence near the breakpoints to that at the centre of the inversion. No statistic falls below a two-sided predictive p of 0.05. Without gene flux the joint fit is poorer ($p = 0.09$), mainly because the model almost never produces variants that are rare in 2a and at high frequency in 2+ (two-sided $p = 0.06$ and 0.12 for the two such cells). Both settings reproduce the low-frequency variants shared by the two arrangements (0.064 of variable sites, against 0.031 predicted with gene flux and 0.035 without it, two-sided $p = 0.07$ and 0.29), the setting without gene flux because its younger barrier retains more shared ancestral variation. In the collinear flanks the same class of variants matches the neutral baseline (Supplementary Methods). The model places 2a at its founding frequency when the barrier forms, so t_{inv} dates the recombination barrier together with the founding of the arrangement. The observed joint site-frequency spectrum between

arrangements shows the same barrier directly, with near-fixed differences and off-diagonal density in the inversion and a collapse to the diagonal in collinear controls (Supplementary Fig. S12). Absolute ages scale with the assumed mutation rate $\mu = 3 \times 10^{-9}$, and ages in ka assume one generation per year.

Inversion as a supergene. The barrier to recombination is shown directly by the block of linkage disequilibrium that spans exactly the inversion (Supplementary Fig. S8), by the arrangement differentiation (fig. 3b), and by the joint site-frequency spectrum (Supplementary Fig. S12). There is no evidence that it is locally adaptive across the sampled range, since it shows no cline and geographic $F_{ST} \approx 0$, so the migration-selection scenario that explains most well-studied inversions (Kirkpatrick and Barton, 2006) does not apply here. It is also not a region of strong selective sweep, because the genome-wide scan below finds no cross-method-concordant sweep inside the inversion. The RAiSD footprint statistic is broadly elevated and the classifier over-calls across the inversion, but the two never colocalize into focal concordance, as expected for selection on the arrangement as a whole rather than on a focal swept locus, and the concordance requirement filters these calls. Gene flux between arrangements leaves no gradient in mean d_{xy} from the breakpoints to the centre, though a residual ∼33% depletion of near-fixed differences appears in the outermost megabase around the breakpoints, and the fitted model reproduces variants rare in 2a and common in 2+ better with gene flux than without it. The derived arrangement has held an intermediate frequency for about 310 ky, and model choice favours an equilibrium maintained by balancing selection over a sweep that is still under way or one that stalled. The mechanism of a balanced equilibrium, whether overdominance, associative overdominance, frequency dependence, or a moving optimum under fluctuating selection, cannot be resolved from these data alone. A shelf-spawning squid whose paralarvae ride the Gulf Stream may well experience temporally fluctuating selection on ∼100 ky glacial cycles, but this remains a hypothesis, because fluctuating selection was not among the simulated models.

Gene content and the architecture of arrangement divergence. The inversion has no functionally significant enrichment. Its 89 gene models (4.7 per Mb, against 6.8 per Mb genome-wide) place it at the 15th percentile of autosomal windows of the same size (median 127 genes, interquartile range 100–151). Its annotated content is equally low, with 45 genes carrying a cross-species functional annotation and 29 carrying gene-ontology terms, again the 15th percentile (median 49 GO-annotated genes per window). Their functional classes are diverse (lipid metabolism, DNA repair, transcription and splicing, signalling) with no coherent pathway (Supplementary Table S4). A gene-ontology test of its annotated genes against the genome returns no enriched terms at FDR<0.05, and in a permutation null, random gene sets of the same size produce more nominal hits than the inversion genes (86.6±60 against 69, permutation $p = 0.51$), while the largest nominal per-term enrichments (∼40-fold) rest on as few as two genes (Supplementary Fig. S13). The inversion thus appears as a functionally unremarkable slice of the genome, and likely not a selected gene set but instead a supergene maintained for the arrangement as a whole. What the arrangements do accumulate is divergence as a unit. In the genotype-likelihood joint spectrum of 40 2a/2a and 40 2+/2+ individuals (a fixed subset of each group that keeps the two-dimensional spectrum tractable, Supplementary Methods), 3,828 sites are near-fixed between the arrangements and shared polymorphism falls to 18%, whereas collinear chromosome-2 sequence has no near-fixed sites and 47% shared polymorphism (Supplementary Fig. S12). In the called genotypes of all arrangement homozygotes, 5,432 sites spread across the inversion differ in allele frequency between arrangements by at least 0.9, against none in collinear chr2:10–30 Mb, and these positions locate the

coding differences described below. These are overwhelmingly non-coding since coding sequence is only ∼0.2% of the region, but the exonic fixed differences are ∼2.1-fold over-represented and clustered. All 26 fall in just ten genes, led by an acidic-repeat protein (six) and a cytochrome P450 (*CYP4X1*, five) and including a phospholipase A2, the ciliary gene *RPGRIP1L*, and a cysteine-rich venom-like protein. Coding sequence inside the inversion is no more diverged between arrangements than the sequence around it. Per-transcript d_{xy} between arrangements, normalised to its own 100-kb window, exceeds the 95th percentile of collinear control transcripts in 5 of 95 transcripts, as expected by chance (Supplementary Methods). The most differentiated coding sites are depleted of nonsynonymous (zero-fold degenerate) positions, 45% of the top 1% by between-arrangement F_{ST} against 82% of all coding sites in the inversion (odds ratio 0.18), but collinear control sequence shows the same depletion (odds ratio 0.44), as expected when F_{ST} is pulled down at constrained, weakly polymorphic sites, so the depletion is not specific to the inversion.

2.3 Demographic history shows an expanding population

The selection scan below depends on the population's demography, and both it and the inversion model assume the standard Kingman coalescent. Genome-wide, *Illex illecebrosus* shows $\pi \approx 0.0093$, close to the 1.06% heterozygosity estimated from k-mers of the individual used for the assembly (Small et al., 2026), and Tajima's $D \approx -2$ in essentially every window (Tajima, 1989a,b), a genome-wide pattern consistent with population expansion (table 3, fig. 4a, fig. 6). A moments fit to the folded SFS gives growth from an ancestral $N_e = 547{,}928$ to a present $N_e = 6{,}808{,}096$ over 769,519 generations (∼12-fold, with generations equal to years in this annual species, 95% confidence intervals in table 3), and this history reproduces both the observed π and a full-SFS Tajima's $D = -1.92$ under forward simulation. Stairway Plot 2 also recovers a strong expansion, with a most recent median N_e of 1.5×10^7 (95% CI 1.1–1.7 $\times 10^7$). This value lies against the upper limit of θ in the Stairway Plot 2 fit ($N_e = 1.67 \times 10^7$), so it is less well constrained than the moments estimate. The Stairway Plot 2 median also dips about 20-fold, to 7×10^5, between about 1,200 and 3,000 generations ago (95% CI at the minimum 1.7×10^5–3.0×10^6). The moments model does not reproduce this dip and GONE2 does not reach back that far, so we treat it as an unresolved fluctuation of the kind Stairway Plot 2 often produces at recent times rather than as evidence of a bottleneck. GONE2, which resolves only the last ∼150 generations, gives a stable N_e of 4.8–5.0 million under an assumed uniform recombination rate of 1 cM/Mb. Because sweepstakes reproduction would mimic expansion by inflating rare variants (Eldon and Wakeley, 2006; Hedgecock and Pudovkin, 2011; Eldon et al., 2015), we tested the coalescent class directly. The folded SFS is fit far better by a Kingman-plus-growth model than by any multiple-merger (Beta) coalescent (Schweinsberg, 2003). The summed absolute deviation of the normalised spectrum from the model is $L_1 = 0.036$ for Kingman with growth, against 0.108 for the best Beta coalescent ($\alpha = 1.35$ of $\alpha = 1.05$–1.99), which overshoots singletons and undershoots doubletons and tripletons by about 20% (Supplementary Methods). The expansion began ∼770 ka.

2.4 Recombination, background selection, and protein adaptation

Three further features of the genome were resolved to accurately identify selective sweeps. Recombination was estimated with ReLERNN (Adrion et al., 2020), a deep-learning method that infers the rate from patterns of linkage in genotype data. The estimated rate is ∼0.24 cM/Mb on the autosomes (median 0.241, Supplementary Fig. S14). The map is flat with respect to gene content, and the rate differs by only ∼2% between windows adjacent to exons and windows >100 kb from any exon, unchanged when π is held fixed (Supplementary Fig. S15a). For example, on chromosome 1

the 2-Mb rolling median spans just 0.22–0.27 cM/Mb, the pericentromeric flanks where π halves show no more than a 7% dip, and the centromere itself (a 2.5-Mb block that is 80% repeat) carries no windows over its central 1.1 Mb (Supplementary Fig. S16). This pattern is similar genome-wide. Across the 44 autosomes in the map the chromosome-scale rolling median varies by 13–67% of each chromosome's median, and no chromosome shows a peak more than 17% above it. Background selection is moderate and gene-density-driven. Nucleotide diversity falls with local coding density ($r = -0.31$, a 20–30% reduction in gene-dense windows) and rises 43% between exon-adjacent and exon-distant windows (Supplementary Fig. S15) (Charlesworth et al., 1993; McVicker et al., 2009; Charlesworth and Jensen, 2021). A model-based B-map could not be fit with bgspy, whose classical approximation diverges in this regime, where the deleterious mutation rate exceeds the selection coefficient, so local coding fraction serves as the background-selection covariate that the sweep scan controls for explicitly. Protein adaptation over the divergence timescale is substantial. McDonald–Kreitman tests (McDonald and Kreitman, 1991; Messer and Petrov, 2013a) against *I. coindetii* across 20,999 genes give a genome-wide proportion of adaptive substitutions of $\alpha = 0.34$ from the pooled counts and 0.64 (95% CI 0.63–0.66) by the asymptotic method, which corrects for slightly deleterious polymorphism, with the splicing factor *SF3B4* the single most significantly adaptive gene (Supplementary Fig. S17). Per-gene power is limited, so we treat the MK results as complementary to the recent-sweep scan, which detects a different timescale of selection. Comparing to *I. argentinus* we find that it is recently diverged (an order of magnitude fewer fixed coding differences than *I. coindetii*, Supplementary Table S3) yet carries similar genome-wide diversity ($\pi = 0.0092$ vs 0.0093), although its estimate comes from ten individuals at $\sim$0.3$\times$ on six autosomes, so the two are large-N_e congeners of comparable standing variation. We also found twenty-two blocks of $\geq$1 Mb on 17 chromosomes (129 Mb, 3.9% of the autosomes) that carry 2.1–6.1 times the chromosome-median π with less negative Tajima's D (Supplementary Table S5). They are present at the same strength in every sampling location, are no more differentiated among locations than flanking sequence, and lack the long-range linkage disequilibrium of a segregating inversion (Supplementary Figs. S18, S19). Read-depth analyses resolve them into three categories. In six, depth is raised in every individual (1.2–2.2 times the flanks across the population sample, and up to 2.7 and 2.4 times in long reads from the individual used for the assembly and a second individual (Small et al., 2026)), and a single diploid genome carries five to six times the flanking density of heterozygous sites at skewed allele fractions. We interpret this as a duplicated sequence collapsed into one copy in the assembly. In eight, short-read depth is reduced to 0.6–0.9 times the flanks in every individual. A third of their accessible sequence is not uniquely mappable by 150-bp reads, against 4% genome-wide, so these blocks are largely duplicated within the assembly itself and short reads there map to several places and are lost at the mapping-quality filters. Long reads, which map uniquely through the duplicated sequence, show a much smaller deficit, and divergent haplotypes may add to the loss. The remaining eight have normal depth and mapping and are gene-poor regions of genuinely elevated diversity. Since our summary statistics cannot separate any of these from the footprints of selection, all 22 blocks were excluded from the sweep scan and the gene-set analyses.

2.5 A genome-wide scan for selective sweeps

We scanned for recent positive selection with diploS/HIC (Schrider and Kern, 2016; Kern and Schrider, 2018), a five-class site-frequency/diversity-based classifier (neutral, hard, soft, linked-hard, and linked-soft, in 1.1 Mb feature windows of eleven 100 kb sub-windows) trained on forward and coalescent simulations under the fitted growth demography with the final model reaching 81% class accuracy (fig. 5, Supplementary Figs. S20 and S21). Applied to the genome, the classifier

over-calls sweeps, assigning only 1% of windows to the neutral class and 91% to the linked-hard or linked-soft classes. This is because real neutral windows (accessible, ≥5 kb from any gene) carry 3–8-fold more within-window spatial heterogeneity in π and θ than the simulations, even though their marginal SFS matches ($D \approx -2$). Simulations with the same missing-data structure and sample incompleteness do not reproduce this excess, which therefore reflects real per-sub-window diversity variation (mutation-rate variation plus background selection) that a uniform-θ coalescent does not reproduce (Johri et al., 2022). We therefore use the classifier as a stratified empirical-outlier detector, in which the sweep score ($p_{\text{hard}} + p_{\text{soft}}$) is ranked within strata of callable fraction and coding density, so a window is an outlier only relative to windows of similar accessibility and gene density, and calls are corroborated by an independent LD-footprint method, RAiSD (Alachiotis and Pavlidis, 2018), or a composite-likelihood SFS method, SweepFinder2 (Nielsen et al., 2005; DeGiorgio et al., 2016). Thus, we report sweeps at two levels of stringency (Supplementary Fig. S22). Tier 1 is the diploS/HIC hard/soft classification, spatially resolved by a recombination-aware Markov decoder, a hidden Markov model over the per-window (100 kb) classes with neutral, linked, and sweep-centre states whose emissions are the prior-corrected class posteriors and whose dwell lengths follow the ∼400 kb sweep footprint scaled by the recombination map (Supplementary Fig. S22a). Because the genome reads as ∼91% linked-selected under strong expansion, the decoder's role is spatial coherence. It retains hard/soft windows that lie in contiguous sweep centers and discards spatially isolated ones, reducing 1,651 raw hard/soft windows to 677 and preferentially keeping the higher-outlier windows (median empirical-outlier percentile 0.98 vs 0.95 for discarded windows, Supplementary Fig. S22b). Retained windows separated by no more than one window are merged into 623 localized autosomal calls (437 hard and 186 soft). Tier 2 is the subset independently corroborated by other methods, producing 24 concordant regions (a diploS/HIC-HMM outlier plus RAiSD or SweepFinder2). Chance alignment of outliers produces far fewer. Shifting the RAiSD and SweepFinder2 outlier track circularly along each chromosome, which keeps the number and clustering of its outliers but breaks their alignment with the diploS/HIC outliers, gives 4.8 concordant regions on average (95% range 1–9, and never more than 16 in 10,000 shifts), so the false-discovery rate of the concordant set is about 0.20. The two tiers agree strongly, with 88% of windows at concordant loci decoded as sweep centers versus 2.9% genome-wide (odds ratio 242, $p < 10^{-30}$), and 21 of the 24 concordant regions contain a Tier-1 center (Supplementary Fig. S22c), so the conservative concordance set is a high-purity subset of the classifier calls, not a disjoint list. The Z chromosome is necessarily diploS/HIC-only and scanned separately in males (below), it contributes four further Tier-1 calls, for a genome-wide Tier-1 total of 627 (fig. 5, Supplementary Fig. S23).

Neurodevelopment and photoreception. The 623 autosomal Tier-1 calls overlap 885 genes (475 with GO annotation). Of the 623 calls, 190 (30%) overlap no gene model and so do not enter the enrichment analyses. A gene-ontology enrichment against the annotated-gene background (Fisher's exact test with Benjamini–Hochberg FDR, Benjamini and Hochberg 1995) returns 124 terms at FDR<0.05 (Supplementary Fig. S24, Table S6), dominated by neural development (neurogenesis, generation of neurons, neuron development, neuron-projection and cell morphogenesis, at 1.5–1.8-fold), together with transcriptional and RNA-regulatory control, and a weaker light-response signal (response to light stimulus 1.9-fold, response to radiation 1.8-fold). The hard-sweep calls alone give 98 terms at FDR<0.05, 85 of them among the 124 and including every term in Supplementary Table S6 and both light-response terms, and the disjoint soft-sweep set, with 142 GO-annotated genes against 333 for the hard calls, has none at FDR<0.05. Because background selection also lowers diversity in gene-dense regions, we screened every Tier-1 call with the same per-region

background-selection test used for the concordant set, retaining only calls whose local π falls below the background-selection expectation given flanking coding density. This keeps 291 of the 623 (237 hard, 54 soft). The BGS-robust set yields 151 terms at FDR<0.05, and every leading term's fold enrichment rises over the previous set, including response to light stimulus $1.94 \rightarrow 3.15$ (FDR $2\times10^{-2} \rightarrow 9\times10^{-5}$), response to radiation $1.76 \rightarrow 2.79$ (FDR $3\times10^{-2} \rightarrow 2\times10^{-4}$), neuron-projection morphogenesis $1.81 \rightarrow 2.25$, cell morphogenesis $1.73 \rightarrow 2.24$, neuron development $1.59 \rightarrow 1.97$, generation of neurons $1.59 \rightarrow 1.90$, transcription by RNA polymerase II $1.73 \rightarrow 2.08$ (Supplementary Fig. S24). The photoreception signal, the weakest in the full set, becomes the single most enriched theme after the BGS screen, and its more specific child terms (detection of light stimulus $2.5 \rightarrow 3.9$, phototransduction $2.5 \rightarrow 3.4$) move in the same direction, though with too few genes to reach significance. A shared-gene enrichment map of the BGS-robust set resolves the same two connected modules, neural development/morphogenesis and light response, with no third (Supplementary Fig. S25, Table S7).

Candidate sweeps. The Tier-2 concordant regions carry a biologically coherent set of cephalopod-orthologous genes that sit squarely within these themes (table 4, Supplementary Table S8). They include the neural/EMT transcription factor *ZEB2*, the synaptic-vesicle GTPase *Rab3*, the apelin receptor *Aplnr* (cardiovascular/vasculature signalling), the DNA-damage-response gene *MACROD2*, the phospholipid synthase *cept1*, and the ceramide phosphoethanolamine synthase *Cpes*. A per-region background-selection test isolates 11 of these as high-confidence candidates in which diversity is reduced beyond the background-selection expectation. Fine-scale localization (Supplementary Methods) places one gene-desert signal on an annotated transposable element (flagged lower confidence) and moves two targets to neighboring genes, from *eif3h* to *Cpes* at chr1:85.5 Mb and to *GALT* at chr25:65.0 Mb. The single most distinctive autosomal candidate is a cephalopod-lineage-specific gene under a hard sweep on chromosome 16, a tandem-exon transcript with no functional annotation whose translation matches an uncharacterised protein family in the bobtail squid *Euprymna* (NCBI BLASTX against nr, $E = 2 \times 10^{-53}$, 40% identity) (Albertin et al., 2022). There is no overlap between the sweep candidates and the MK-adaptive genes.

The Z chromosome. Because males are Z-diploid and females Z-haploid, the Z was scanned separately in the 329 confident ZZ males, using a model retrained at the matched sample size and accounting for the Z's reduced effective size. The male-only screen was validated against 278 haploid females (including five with low-confidence sex calls), whose per-window diversity tracks the males' at $r = 0.996$. Of the four Z Tier-1 calls (three hard and one soft, Supplementary Fig. S23), three credible, gene-localised sweeps survive fine-scale triage, all confirmed as conserved cephalopod genes by direct homology. These are *Pasilla*/Nova-1 (a neuronal alternative-splicing regulator with 92% identity to its *Octopus* ortholog), *Smaug*/samd4a (a germline RNA-binding translational repressor), and *Esrrg* (an estrogen-related receptor with an adjacent likely *cis*-regulatory lncRNA, with 97.5% identity to its *Octopus* ortholog), a coherent RNA-regulation-and-hormone-signalling signature on a sex chromosome that, in the companion analysis of the assembly and its transcriptomes (Small et al., 2026), is dosage compensated, enriched for chromatin-modifying genes and carries two conserved sex-biased lncRNAs with RNA-binding-protein sites. *Amnionless*, with the female-biased lncRNA *Zfest* transcribed antisense to it (Small et al., 2026), falls just outside the swept valley and shows only purifying selection, so it is a linked passenger rather than the target.

3 Discussion

The inversion is a datable supergene whose derived arrangement is held by balancing selection. Chromosomal inversions are often maintained by local adaptation in the presence of gene flow, producing geographic clines in arrangement frequency (Kirkpatrick and Barton, 2006; Lowry and Willis, 2010; Faria et al., 2019). That explanation does not fit *Illex illecebrosus*. The chromosome-2 inversion is distributed throughout the species' range, its frequency is non-clinal, and geographic differentiation is effectively absent. Instead, the inversion appears to represent a long-lived polymorphism under selection at the level of the arrangement. The derived arrangement (2a) retains substantially less diversity than expected from its current frequency, indicating that it was at lower frequency in the past. Model choice with a barrier-aware coalescent simulator favours balancing selection over neutral drift and directional selection, and neural posterior estimation supports an age of about 390,000 years and a history in which the derived arrangement began to rise from a founding frequency near 0.05 about 310,000 years ago towards an equilibrium near 0.60, where it has been held since.

This history differs from that of classic *Drosophila* inversions, whose frequencies often vary across geographic or seasonal gradients (Corbett-Detig and Hartl, 2012; Kapun and Flatt, 2019), and from the human 17q21 inversion, whose derived H2 arrangement appears to be under ongoing positive selection (Stefansson et al., 2005). Why the derived arrangement is held at an intermediate frequency is the open question. One possible analogue is the mimicry supergene of *Heliconius numata*, in which an inverted arrangement carries recessive deleterious variation that contributes to associative overdominance and limits its frequency (Jay et al., 2021). Associative overdominance is therefore one plausible mechanism in *Illex illecebrosus*, particularly because large non-recombining regions can accumulate recessive load (Zhao and Charlesworth, 2016; Gilbert et al., 2020; Berdan et al., 2021). The inversion contains clustered coding divergence, including 26 fixed exonic differences across ten genes, providing potential substrate for such a load, although the differentiated coding sites are not enriched for nonsynonymous changes. Other mechanisms remain possible. Temporally fluctuating selection can maintain polymorphism over long periods in natural populations (Wittmann et al., 2017; Rudman et al., 2022). For a shelf-spawning squid whose paralarvae are transported by the Gulf Stream, repeated environmental change across glacial cycles provides a plausible ecological context.

The data therefore resolve the historical trajectory more clearly than the selective mechanism. They support selection acting on the inversion as an integrated genomic unit rather than on a single identifiable locus within it. The region is gene-poor, lacks functional enrichment, contains thousands of highly differentiated variants distributed across the block, and shows no evidence of a localized selective sweep. Together, these features are consistent with long-term selection on the alternative chromosomal arrangements as supergenes (Kirkpatrick, 2010; Berdan et al., 2023).

The derived arrangement may not have started from a single copy. The fitted history favours a start from a founding frequency of about 0.05 over a start from a single copy, which carries 3% of the posterior mass, so the barrier age is the age of a polymorphism already present in several copies and not necessarily that of a single new inversion. A start from more than one copy is plausible here for structural reasons. Chromosome 2 is extensively rearranged between *Illex illecebrosus* and *I. coindetii*, and the segregating inversion lies inside an older inverted block whose right breakpoint it reuses. This part of chromosome 2 has therefore rearranged repeatedly, and a region whose breakpoints are reused may also produce the same arrangement more than once, giving the derived arrangement several independent founding copies. The polarity rests on two outgroups, and chromosome 2 is rearranged in this region in both. *I. coindetii* keeps the 2+

order only across the left breakpoint, because the older inverted block shares the right breakpoint. *S. oualaniensis* keeps the 2+ adjacency and lacks the 2a adjacency at both breakpoints, so the two outgroups agree that 2+ is ancestral at both breakpoints. Because chromosome 2 rearranges so often in this lineage, the common ancestor may still have carried an intermediate form elsewhere in the region, and this agreement is support rather than proof. At most sites that differ between the arrangements 2+ carries the *I. coindetii* allele, and the minority at which 2a carries it fit variation that was segregating when 2a formed and was captured by it, possibly in more than one founding event (Supplementary Methods). Reads from *I. argentinus* show the same pattern. Each of ten individuals carries the 2+ allele at about 70% of these sites, its 2a alleles fall mostly where *I. coindetii* also carries the 2a allele, and none shows the inversion segregating, so the polymorphism is not shared with this close congener. The trajectory models assume this polarity, with 2a as the arrangement that founded and rose. Other routes lead to the same soft start. The arrangement may, for example, have reached intermediate frequency in a partially isolated population and entered the main population by secondary contact. In the ABC-RF reference table, single-copy starts carry only 3% of the posterior mass of balancing selection (Supplementary Methods), so a soft start is favoured, but these routes to a soft start predict similar genealogies and are not distinguished.

Methodological lessons. Two methodological lessons from this analysis may be broadly useful for inversion studies. First, divergence between the two arrangements, which carries much of the information on an inversion's age, is symmetric with respect to their ancestral and derived states, whereas a frequency history is not. Polarization therefore matters most for the trajectory, which matters here because the reference is uninformative and the outgroup comparison is not simple. The *Illex illecebrosus* reference individual is heterozygous for the inversion, so the reference orientation carries no information about ancestry, and the outgroup comparison rests on a region that has rearranged repeatedly. More generally, assuming that the reference orientation is ancestral creates a circularity in inversion polarization. Phased haplotype assemblies of the reference individual and the order of outgroup sequence across the whole rearranged segment, not only its orientation, polarize an inversion independently of the reference sequence.

Second, the genealogy of a segregating inversion is not adequately represented by treating the alternative arrangements as freely recombining chromosomes or as allelic states at a single locus. Suppressed recombination between arrangements instead creates a structured coalescent resembling two partially isolated demes separated by a recombination barrier (Navarro et al., 2000; Guerrero et al., 2012). Modeling this history therefore requires the barrier to be represented explicitly in the ancestral recombination graph. The `msinv` simulator implements this process, so that competing frequency histories of the inversion can be compared by simulation-based inference from within-arrangement diversity, divergence between arrangements, the site-frequency spectra and linkage disequilibrium. In *Illex illecebrosus*, this framework estimates the age of the inversion and the long phase at a balanced equilibrium and bounds its founding frequency, whose posterior (median 0.05) extends to the upper limit of its prior at 0.10, features that would be lost by reducing the inversion to a single-locus polymorphism. As genomic surveys identify increasing numbers of segregating inversions in natural populations (Wellenreuther and Bernatchez, 2018; Mérot et al., 2020), reconstructing their age and frequency trajectories may provide a useful way to distinguish among inversion histories even when their phenotypic effects are unknown.

Selective sweeps are enriched near neural and photoreceptive genes and are robust to background selection. The genome-wide sweep scan identified two prominent functional themes. The first encompasses neurogenesis, neuron development, and neuron-projection and cell

morphogenesis, consistent with a coleoid lineage characterized by a large, centralized, and cell-type-rich nervous system (Albertin et al., 2015; Styfhals et al., 2022). Coleoid genomes also show extensive regulatory reorganization around neural genes (Schmidbaur et al., 2022). A related signal has been reported in another coleoid lineage. In the sibling octopuses *Octopus bimaculatus* and *O. bimaculoides*, genes associated with brain and eye development are enriched among targets of positive selection (Coffing et al., 2026). Together, these observations suggest that neural and visual functions may be recurrent targets of selection across independently evolving coleoid lineages.

The second theme involves photoreception and response to light. Cephalopod photoreception extends beyond the camera eye, with opsins and components of phototransduction pathways expressed in the skin and chromatophore system (Ramirez and Oakley, 2015; Kingston et al., 2015). Their visual systems are also unusually complex, including highly differentiated optic lobes that evolved independently of the vertebrate visual system (Songco-Casey et al., 2022; Styfhals et al., 2022; Yoshida et al., 2015). In *Illex illecebrosus*, this signal has a plausible ecological context. The species is a visually guided predator that undergoes diel vertical migration through strong gradients in illumination and large seasonal movements across latitude (O'Dor and Dawe, 1998). These observations do not identify the selective pressure responsible for individual sweeps, but they provide a biological context for the repeated association of sweep candidates with light-response genes.

A central concern is whether these enrichments could arise from background selection rather than recent positive selection. Diversity is reduced in gene-dense regions of the *Illex illecebrosus* genome, as expected under background selection (Charlesworth et al., 1993; McVicker et al., 2009; Charlesworth and Jensen, 2021), and neural-development genes could therefore be over-represented among low-diversity windows even in the absence of sweeps. We addressed this directly by requiring candidate regions to show a reduction in diversity beyond that expected from local coding density. Rather than weakening after this filter, the major functional signals became stronger. Enrichment for response to light increased from 1.9- to 3.2-fold, response to radiation from 1.8- to 2.8-fold, and morphogenesis-related terms from approximately 1.7–1.8- to 2.2–2.3-fold. Light response, initially the weaker of the two major themes, became the strongest after the background-selection screen. Thus, the neural and photoreceptive enrichments cannot be readily explained by gene density and its associated reduction in neutral diversity alone.

We nevertheless treat the individual sweep loci as candidates rather than confirmed targets of positive selection. Simulation-trained window classifiers such as diploS/HIC provide a powerful framework for detecting recent selection (Schrider and Kern, 2016; Kern and Schrider, 2018), but their absolute classification proved poorly calibrated in this genome. Although the simulated data reproduced the fitted demography, empirical sample size, and missing-data structure, putatively neutral genomic windows contained substantially more fine-scale heterogeneity in diversity than the simulations. This mismatch caused widespread classification of real genomic windows as linked to sweeps. We therefore did not interpret the raw classifier output directly. Instead, we ranked sweep scores empirically within strata of callable sequence and coding density, required spatial coherence with a recombination-aware decoder, and used independent RAiSD or SweepFinder2 support to define the most conservative candidate set. An additional background-selection screen then tested whether local diversity was lower than expected from coding density. This layered approach follows the broader principle that selection scans should explicitly accommodate genomic features that cannot be reproduced adequately by the null model (Johri et al., 2022).

Hard-sweep classifications predominate among the retained candidates, which is potentially interesting because large populations with abundant standing variation are often expected to provide favorable conditions for soft sweeps (Messer and Petrov, 2013b). Hard sweeps can instead arise when adaptation depends on new or initially rare variants, particularly when the mutational target is limited (Hermisson and Pennings, 2005; Harris et al., 2018). However, we do not regard

the apparent excess of hard sweeps as strong evidence for a particular mode of adaptation. The soft-sweep class is less well resolved in these unphased data, and the imperfect calibration of the classifier further limits inference about the relative prevalence of hard and soft sweeps. The more robust conclusion is therefore the localization and functional enrichment of candidate sweep regions, rather than their assignment to a specific sweep class.

Demography, sweepstakes reproduction, and the interpretation of selection. The demographic history of *Illex illecebrosus* is important not only as a description of population history, but also because it determines the genealogical null against which the sweep scan is interpreted. Genome-wide Tajima's D is approximately -2 across nearly all of the accessible genome, and the folded SFS is consistent with a major historical expansion. The fitted moments model places the onset of this expansion at approximately 770,000 years ago, with N_e increasing from about 5.5×10^5 to 6.8×10^6, a roughly 12-fold increase. Stairway Plot 2 recovers the same expansion, and GONE2, which covers only the last $\sim$150 generations, gives a contemporary N_e of the same order. For an annual, highly fecund pelagic species, this combination of a large N_e, abundant rare variation, and very weak geographic differentiation is consistent with a population that has remained both large and highly connected over much of its recent evolutionary history.

High fecundity alone, however, makes this interpretation non-trivial. Marine broadcast spawners are canonical candidates for sweepstakes reproductive success, in which a small and variable fraction of adults contributes disproportionately to subsequent generations (Eldon and Wakeley, 2006; Hedgecock and Pudovkin, 2011). Under sufficiently extreme reproductive skew, genealogies can depart from the binary-merger Kingman coalescent and instead approach a multiple-merger coalescent, producing an excess of rare variants that can resemble demographic expansion. Recurrent selective sweeps can generate related distortions, and in Atlantic cod, pervasive linked selection has been proposed to contribute to multiple-merger-like genealogies (Árnason et al., 2023). Thus, the strongly negative Tajima's D in *Illex illecebrosus* cannot by itself distinguish population growth from reproductive or selective processes that reshape genealogies.

We therefore tested the coalescent class directly rather than assuming that the life history of *Illex illecebrosus* implied a multiple-merger process. The folded SFS is substantially better fit by Kingman coalescence with population growth than by any of the Beta-coalescent models examined ($L_1 = 0.036$ against at least 0.108 for $\alpha = 1.05$–1.99). These results do not imply that reproductive success is equal among individuals, nor do they exclude sweepstakes reproduction in individual cohorts. Rather, they indicate that reproductive skew is not sufficiently strong or persistent to dominate the genome-wide genealogical process at the temporal and genomic scales represented by these data. Despite its extreme fecundity and semelparous life history, *Illex illecebrosus* therefore does not show the genome-wide multiple-merger signature that might otherwise be expected for a marine broadcast spawner.

This distinction has direct consequences for the evolutionary inferences in this study. First, it supports the use of a Kingman-based neutral baseline for estimating the age and frequency trajectory of the chromosome-2 inversion. Second, it provides a demographic null for the sweep scan in which the genome-wide excess of rare variants is attributed primarily to population growth rather than being treated as evidence of pervasive positive selection. The strong expansion also helps explain why raw sweep classifiers trained under simpler neutral models performed poorly, because the baseline genome is already strongly displaced toward rare variants, leaving recent selection to be identified as a local departure from an unusually non-equilibrium genomic background. Establishing the coalescent and demographic context is therefore a prerequisite for interpreting both forms of selection described here.

Linkage on the Z chromosome indicates achiasmate female meiosis. Sex-specific recombination has not been measured directly in any cephalopod (Coffing et al., 2026), but the ZZ/ZO system (Coffing et al., 2025; Small et al., 2026) provides an indirect test. The Z recombines only in ZZ males and spends two thirds of its time in them, so its population-scaled recombination rate relative to the autosomes depends on the female rate. With a Z effective size of three quarters of the autosomal value, equal recombination in the two sexes predicts a Z-to-autosome ratio of 0.5, whereas achiasmate female meiosis predicts 1 (Coffing et al., 2026). In males, linkage disequilibrium decays at the same rate on the Z as on the autosomes ($\rho_Z/\rho_A = 1.04$, 95% CI 0.88–1.28). Interpreting this ratio requires the effective size of the Z, because Z diversity is lower than effective size alone would predict. Synonymous divergence from *S. oualaniensis* shows that the Z mutates more slowly than the autosomes, with a female mutation rate two to four times the male rate ($\alpha = 0.33$, 95% CI 0.10–0.70), and the female bias persists after matching genes on selective constraint and base composition. The remaining reduction in Z diversity corresponds to a Z effective size of 0.68–0.76 of the autosomal value, close to the expectation under an equal breeding sex ratio, and together these estimates give a male share of recombination $r_m/(r_m + r_f)$ of 1.02–1.14 across the mutation-bias estimates, against 0.5 for equal rates in the two sexes and 1 for achiasmate female meiosis (Supplementary Methods and Table S9). Carrying the 95% CI of the linkage-disequilibrium ratio through gives 0.87–1.41, which excludes the 0.5 expected under equal recombination and includes achiasmy. The same conclusion was reached from the Z of the two-spot octopuses, where a female-biased mutation rate was also found (Coffing et al., 2025, 2026). Because the Z has been conserved as a single syntenic unit across coleoids for more than 300 million years (Coffing et al., 2025; Small et al., 2026), achiasmate female meiosis and female-biased mutation appear to be shared features of the coleoid ZZ/ZO system, consistent with the reduction or loss of recombination in the heterogametic sex that is widespread across animals (Burt et al., 1991; Lenormand and Dutheil, 2005).

4 Limitations

Several uncertainties limit the resolution, rather than the overall interpretation, of our results. Most importantly, the callset is unphased, preventing the use of haplotype-homozygosity statistics and reducing our ability to distinguish hard from soft sweeps. The simulation-trained classifier also remains imperfectly calibrated to the empirical genome because real genomic windows contain substantially more fine-scale diversity heterogeneity than the simulated null. Our empirical stratification, spatial filtering, cross-method corroboration, and background-selection screen reduce sensitivity to this mismatch but do not provide an absolute false-positive rate. We therefore place greater confidence in the recurrent functional enrichment and in candidates supported by multiple lines of evidence than in the classification of individual loci or their assignment to a particular sweep mode. The inversion analysis has different limitations. Its absolute age depends on the assumed mutation rate. The trajectory models impose selection only on the frequency of the arrangement and treat variants within each arrangement as neutral, which is the model our conclusion implies, with selection acting on the arrangement as a unit rather than on individual sites within it. The data therefore constrain when the barrier formed and how the frequency of the derived arrangement changed, but give only a lower bound on the strength of selection and do not identify its mechanism. The model choice is made within four histories, and its posterior probabilities depend on the prior ranges of each. Fluctuating selection, other forms of frequency dependence and structured histories were not modelled. The neutral baseline was fitted to the collinear sequence flanking the inversion on chromosome 2, which is less diverse than the genome-wide average, and its population-scaled recombination rate is lower than the recombination map gives. Its parameters were held at their

fitted values in the model choice. The most obvious structured alternative is an allopatric origin followed by secondary contact, which would produce the same soft start. Drift in an isolate can carry a new arrangement to a frequency of a few percent quickly, and a small isolate would also leave the derived arrangement less diverse than the ancestral one, as observed. An allopatric origin therefore remains possible, but it does not remove the need for selection, because neutral drift from the founding frequency is rejected. In particular, the present analyses cannot distinguish among associative overdominance, frequency-dependent selection, or temporally varying selection, nor can they identify a phenotype associated with the alternative arrangements. Comparative sampling of the inversion in closely related *Illex* species and direct phenotypic comparison among karyotypes would provide important tests of these alternatives.

Finally, functional annotation remains imperfect. Functional interpretation relies heavily on homology to relatively distant cephalopod models, leaving many lineage-specific genes poorly characterized. The neural and photoreceptive signals should therefore be interpreted primarily as gene-set-level enrichments, while individual candidate genes remain hypotheses for functional validation.

5 Conclusions

The population genome of *Illex illecebrosus* is strikingly homogeneous geographically but not evolutionarily. A conspecific chromosome-level reference reveals genomic variation that was largely inaccessible when population structure was viewed through a divergent reference and geographic differentiation alone. Most notably, a large chromosome-2 inversion persists across an otherwise panmictic population as a deeply differentiated, long-lived polymorphism whose history is inconsistent with neutral drift. Its lack of a geographic cline or obvious functional specialization makes it distinct from many classic inversion systems and emphasizes that the evolutionary history of a supergene can sometimes be reconstructed more clearly than its phenotype or selective mechanism.

Beyond the inversion, the genome records a different mode of selection in localized candidate sweep regions enriched near genes involved in neural development and photoreception. Together, these results show that extensive dispersal and negligible geographic structure do not imply an absence of adaptive genomic variation. Instead, selection in a highly connected marine population can be expressed through persistent structural polymorphism and localized genomic change without producing conventional population subdivision. More broadly, the study illustrates how appropriate reference genomes and analyses that explicitly account for demography, recombination, and genomic heterogeneity can expose evolutionary variation that otherwise remains cryptic.

6 Methods

The main steps are summarised here. Parameter values, thresholds, and software versions are given in the Supplementary Methods and Supplementary Table S10. The scripts for every step are in the `pipeline/` directory of the manuscript repository (https://github.com/stsmall/Illex_popgen), and the inversion analysis is in the msinv repository (https://github.com/stsmall/msinv, Data and code availability).

Samples and variant calling. Baker et al. (2025) whole-genome sequenced 633 *Illex illecebrosus* individuals (ENA project PRJEB101095), collected in 2022 and 2023 across eleven NAFO divisions, with coordinates, date, and capture depth recorded for each collection event (Supplementary Table S1). That study retained 616 individuals after quality filtering and analyzed 540 after removing individuals with more than 25% missing genotypes. We re-processed the raw reads from scratch

against the conspecific `Illex_F24` primary assembly (Small et al., 2026) (3.47 Gb in 45 numbered chromosomes plus the Z). Twelve of the 633 alignments hold almost no reads (fewer than 2.1 million autosomal reads, against a median of 57 million), and these individuals were excluded. Two further individuals (SQ23HBB023 and SQ23HBB124) were excluded as likely contaminated, with male-like heterozygosity on the Z under female coverage calls, Z coverage above every male and extreme positions on the autosomal principal components. A third, SQ233K026, was excluded last as a possible mixed sample, with a 2a/2+ karyotype from genotype likelihoods against 2a/2a from the principal components and the same Z signature. Counts and frequencies are for the remaining 618. Genome-wide analyses run before the first two exclusions and the pooled linkage-disequilibrium map of the inversion include all three, and all other analyses, including the inversion statistics and model fits, use 619 individuals and include SQ233K026 (Supplementary Methods). Reads were trimmed with fastp (Chen et al., 2018), mapped with BWA-MEM2 (Vasimuddin et al., 2019), and deduplicated with Picard, and genotypes were called jointly across individuals with GATK HaplotypeCaller in gVCF mode (Poplin et al., 2017), all within grenepipe (Czech and Exposito-Alonso, 2022). The joint callset retains invariant sites. Variants were filtered on site quality, mapping quality, strand bias, missingness, and excess heterozygosity at intermediate frequency, and sites in GC-corrected high-depth windows or in annotated repeats were excluded, leaving 1.43 Gb of accessible sequence, of which 96% is uniquely mappable by 150-bp reads according to GenMap (Pockrandt et al., 2020). For the sweep scan and gene-set analyses this accessibility mask was extended by the 22 anomalous-diversity blocks described in the Results (Supplementary Table S5). Genotypes are unphased.

Diversity, site-frequency spectra, and demography. Mean sequencing depth is about 9-fold, so diversity statistics were estimated from genotype likelihoods rather than from called genotypes. Folded site-frequency spectra, π, Watterson's θ, and Tajima's D were computed with ANGSD (Korneliussen et al., 2014) directly from the BAM alignments rather than from the VCF, genome-wide, per chromosome, per NAFO division, and per karyotype, with the Z analyzed in males only. Demographic history was inferred with Stairway Plot 2 (Liu and Fu, 2020), moments (Jouganous et al., 2017), and GONE2 (Santiago et al., 2025), and the fitted model was validated by forward simulation. The coalescent class was tested by comparing the folded spectrum with Kingman-plus-growth and Beta-coalescent expectations. Statistics that require individual genotypes were computed on the called genotypes with pg_gpu (Pope et al., 2026). These are the windowed per-arrangement π and d_{xy}, the between-karyotype and between-division Hudson F_{ST} (Bhatia et al., 2013), linkage disequilibrium, and the principal-component analyses, with missing genotypes retained and handled pairwise. Per-SNP geographic F_{ST} was computed with the Hudson estimator (Bhatia et al., 2013) from per-division allele counts produced by plink2 (Chang et al., 2015), as the ratio of averages over all informative division pairs. Relatedness was screened with KING-robust (Manichaikul et al., 2010).

The chromosome-2 inversion. Karyotypes were assigned by local PCA (Li and Ralph, 2019) and a Gaussian-mixture model on the first principal component, and checked by repeating the assignment on reads downsampled to a common depth of about 1× (Supplementary Methods). The two haplotype assemblies of the reference individual were aligned to each other, to the primary assembly, and to *I. coindetii* with minimap2 (Li, 2018), and the orientation of the inversion relative to *I. coindetii* was confirmed with an AnchorWave (Song et al., 2022) whole-genome alignment.

The age and frequency history were inferred from simulations in msinv (Small, 2025), a sequentially Markov coalescent simulator that enforces the recombination barrier between arrangements

(Supplementary Methods). Each simulation draws a stochastic frequency path for 2a under one of four models (neutral drift, directional selection with or without a later stop, and balancing selection), from a single copy or from a founding frequency, and keeps it only if it ends within 0.02 of the present frequency. It then simulates 40 kb of inversion and a separate 40 kb of collinear control, and computes 39 summary statistics divided, where they have one, by the same statistic in the control, as the data are divided by the collinear flanks. The same frequency paths simulated over the full 19-Mb inversion give statistics whose means differ from those of the 40-kb simulations by less than 0.2 standard deviations (Supplementary Methods).

Model choice used ABC-RF (Pudlo et al., 2016) on a reference table of 3,000–5,000 accepted simulations per history with gene flux. Parameters of the favoured model were estimated by NPE in sbi (Tejero-Cantero et al., 2020; Boelts et al., 2025), with an ensemble of neural spline flows (Durkan et al., 2019) trained on about 60,000 new simulations from its prior that passed the same present-frequency filter, and calibration was checked on 2,000 held-out simulations (Supplementary Methods). The neutral baseline (exponential growth from 507,288 to 9,112,696 over 382,957 generations, $r = 5.51 \times 10^{-10}$) was fitted to the collinear flanks of chromosome 2 by rejection ABC with regression adjustment (Beaumont et al., 2002). The favoured model was checked by posterior predictive simulation from 1,000 NPE draws, including three statistics withheld from the fit.

Gene content, fixed differences between arrangements, gene-ontology enrichment against a permutation null, and the mutational-load test are described in the Supplementary Methods.

Recombination. A recombination map was estimated with ReLERNN (Adrion et al., 2020), which trains a recurrent neural network on coalescent simulations matched to the fitted demography and the accessibility mask and then predicts the rate from the genotype alignment in windows of 3–6 kb. The map was built from the 329 confidently sexed males with data, and a bootstrap correction with 200 replicates was applied. The Z was estimated with a separate network.

Selective sweeps. We classified 100-kb windows with diploS/HIC (Kern and Schrider, 2018), trained on SLiM forward simulations (Haller et al., 2026) recapitated with msprime (Baumdicker et al., 2022; Haller et al., 2019) and on neutral msprime simulations under the fitted demography, at the empirical sample size and with the empirical pattern of missing data. Training and scanning used the same unphased feature extractor and the full site-frequency spectrum. Each window's sweep score was ranked within strata of callable fraction and coding density, and outliers were corroborated with RAiSD (Alachiotis and Pavlidis, 2018) and SweepFinder2 (DeGiorgio et al., 2016). A recombination-aware hidden Markov model resolved the window classifications into spatially coherent Tier-1 calls. The Z was scanned in males only with a model retrained at their sample size. The extended mask excluded the 22 anomalous-diversity blocks throughout. Candidate genes were annotated with EnTAP (Hart et al., 2020) and checked against cephalopod proteomes with DIAMOND (Buchfink et al., 2021). Gene-ontology enrichment used Fisher's exact test with Benjamini–Hochberg correction (Benjamini and Hochberg, 1995), and the background-selection screen retained calls whose local diversity lies at least 0.003 below the value expected from coding density within 1 Mb (Supplementary Methods).

McDonald–Kreitman tests. McDonald–Kreitman tests used mkado (Rivera-Colón et al., 2026) with *I. coindetii* as the outgroup for 20,999 genes, with codon degeneracy annotated by degenotate (Thomas, 2024). Genome-wide α was computed from the pooled counts and by the asymptotic method (Messer and Petrov, 2013a), an exponential fit of $\alpha(x)$ over derived-allele frequencies 0.1–0.9, with a 95% confidence interval from 500 bootstrap resamples of the pooled polymorphisms.

Data and code availability

The manuscript, along with all figures and tables, their generating scripts, and editable table exports, is available in the manuscript repository (https://github.com/stsmall/Illex_popgen), with the scripts for every analysis step in `pipeline/` (https://github.com/stsmall/Illex_popgen/tree/main/pipeline). A section-by-section index of every figure and table source file is provided in `FIGURES_AND_TABLES_INDEX.md`. The annotation utilized is `Illex_F24` version 3, which includes additions to version 2, specifically the loci recovered in the inversion and the chromosome-16 functional note, located in `data/annotation/` within the same repository. Whole-genome sequencing reads for *I. argentinus* will be deposited in the NCBI Sequence Read Archive and the variant calls (VCF) in figshare [accessions to be added]. The coalescent simulations for the inversion analysis (section 2.2) were generated using `msinv` v0.4.1, a sequentially Markov coalescent simulator that enforces the recombination barrier between arrangements (https://github.com/stsmall/msinv, MIT), with the simulation, ABC-RF, NPE and predictive-check code on branch `illex/baseline-refit-karyofix` at commit `36a8b77` (https://github.com/stsmall/msinv/tree/36a8b77de9b9f629e953d4d849b6cca72de6465a). The complete *Illex illecebrosus*-specific inversion analysis, including fitting code, simulation configuration, tabulated outputs, and inversion figures, is contained within the repository under `illex/` and `results/illex/`.

Acknowledgements

[TODO: funding, contribution?.]

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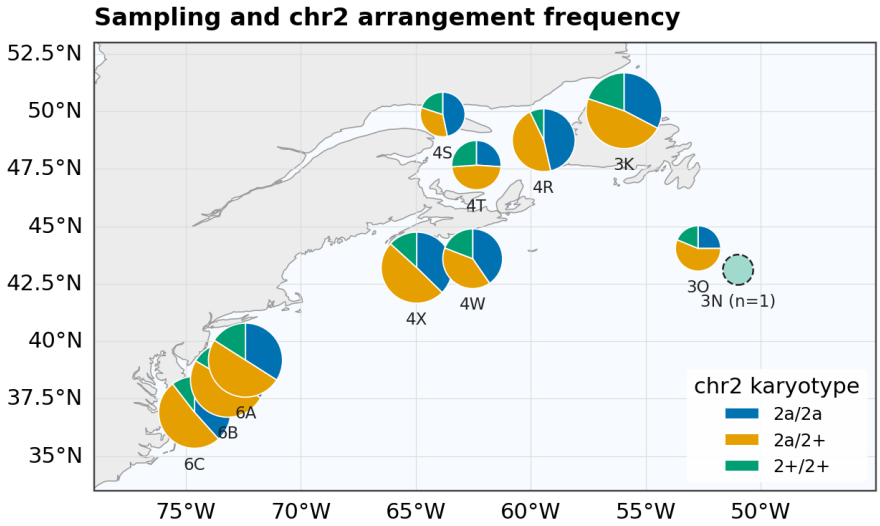


Figure 1: **Sampling and chromosome-2 arrangement frequency.** *Illex illecebrosus* was sampled across eleven NAFO divisions (approximately 37–50°N). The pie charts, positioned at the mean sampling coordinates of each division, illustrate the karyotype composition (2a/2a, 2a/2+ and 2+/2+), with sizes proportional to N. The frequency of the derived (2a) arrangement is non-clinal (ranging from 0.50 to 0.70 across latitudes), which aligns with a geographic $F_{\mathrm{ST}} \approx 0$, giving no indication that the inversion is locally adapted along latitude.

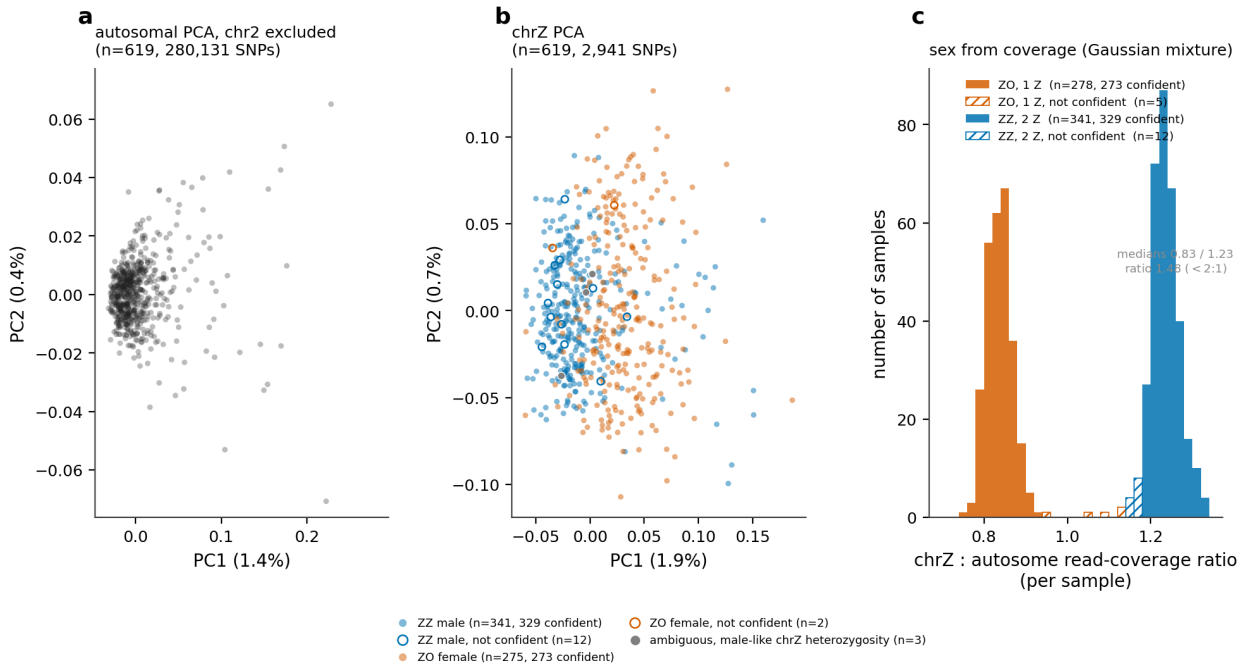


Figure 2: **Absence of population structure outside chromosome 2 and sex assignment** (consistent with the range-wide panmixia reported by Baker et al. 2025). **(a)** Genome-wide autosomal PCA excluding chromosome 2 reveals a single undifferentiated cluster, with PC1 tracking sequencing depth (Supplementary Fig. S2). Variance explained is relative to the full relationship matrix. **(b)** PCA of chrZ, coloured by the sex calls of panel c, shows mild separation between males and females. **(c)** The chrZ:autosome read-coverage ratio per individual separates ZZ males (median 1.23, two Z copies) from ZO females (median 0.83, one Z and no W), with sex assigned by a two-component Gaussian mixture. The ratio counts all mapped reads per base (samtools idxstats, any mapping quality), so reads from repetitive sequence map to the Z in both sexes, which most likely keeps the female value above half the male one (a male-to-female ratio of 1.48 rather than 2). The calls depend on the separation of the two clusters, not on their absolute values. Open symbols and hatched bars mark calls below the confidence threshold. Three mixture-model female calls with male-like chrZ heterozygosity and coverage between the clusters (grey in panel b) were set to not confident. The sample includes 341 males (329 confident) and 277 females (273 confident). SQ233K026, a not-confident female call excluded afterwards, is still plotted.

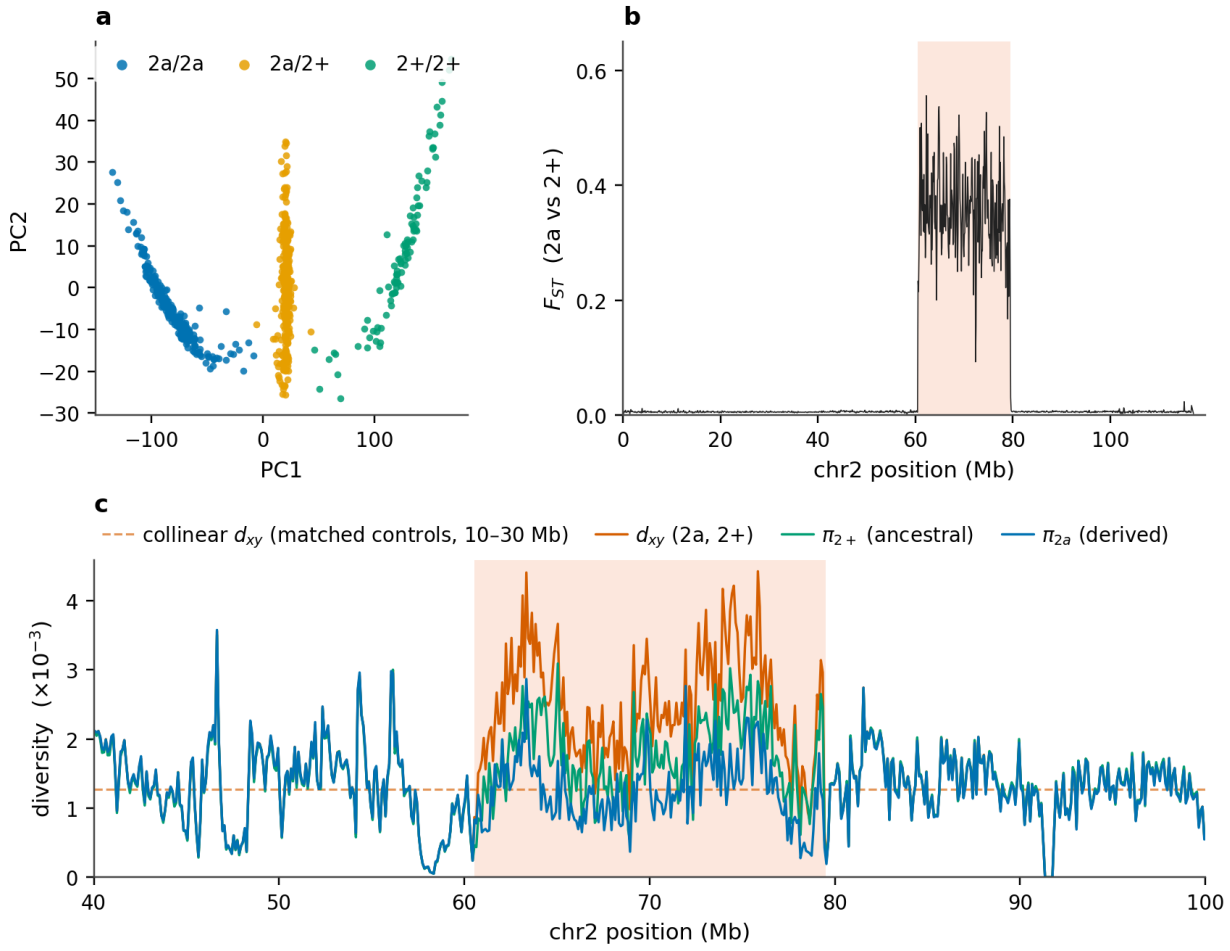


Figure 3: **Chromosome-2 inversion analysis.** **(a)** PCA of chr2 in the 619 individuals distinguishes three karyotype clusters (2a/2a, 2a/2+, 2+/2+). **(b)** F_{ST} values between arrangements along chr2 indicate that the inversion (60.54–79.50 Mb, shaded) is the sole differentiated region (Hudson F_{ST} between the arrangement homozygotes in 100-kb windows, median 0.36 inside the inversion compared to 0.006 in collinear sequence, the same windows as Supplementary Fig. S6). **(c)** Diversity per arrangement in 100-kb windows across the inversion (shaded) and 20 Mb of collinear sequence on either side, computed from called genotypes at biallelic SNPs of all arrangement homozygotes as the mean pairwise difference per site (missing genotypes excluded per site), summed over SNPs and divided by window length without an accessibility mask. Absolute values are therefore lower bounds, 3–4 times below the genotype-likelihood estimates given in the text, whereas ratios between arrangements do not depend on the denominator. Within the breakpoints the derived 2a arrangement is less diverse than the ancestral 2+ ($\pi_I/\pi_S = 0.72$, a ratio unaffected by the denominator), despite its higher frequency, and d_{xy} surpasses both, indicating an ancient polymorphism whose derived arrangement was rarer in the past. Outside the breakpoints, the three curves converge at the collinear d_{xy} (dashed), as expected where arrangements recombine freely.

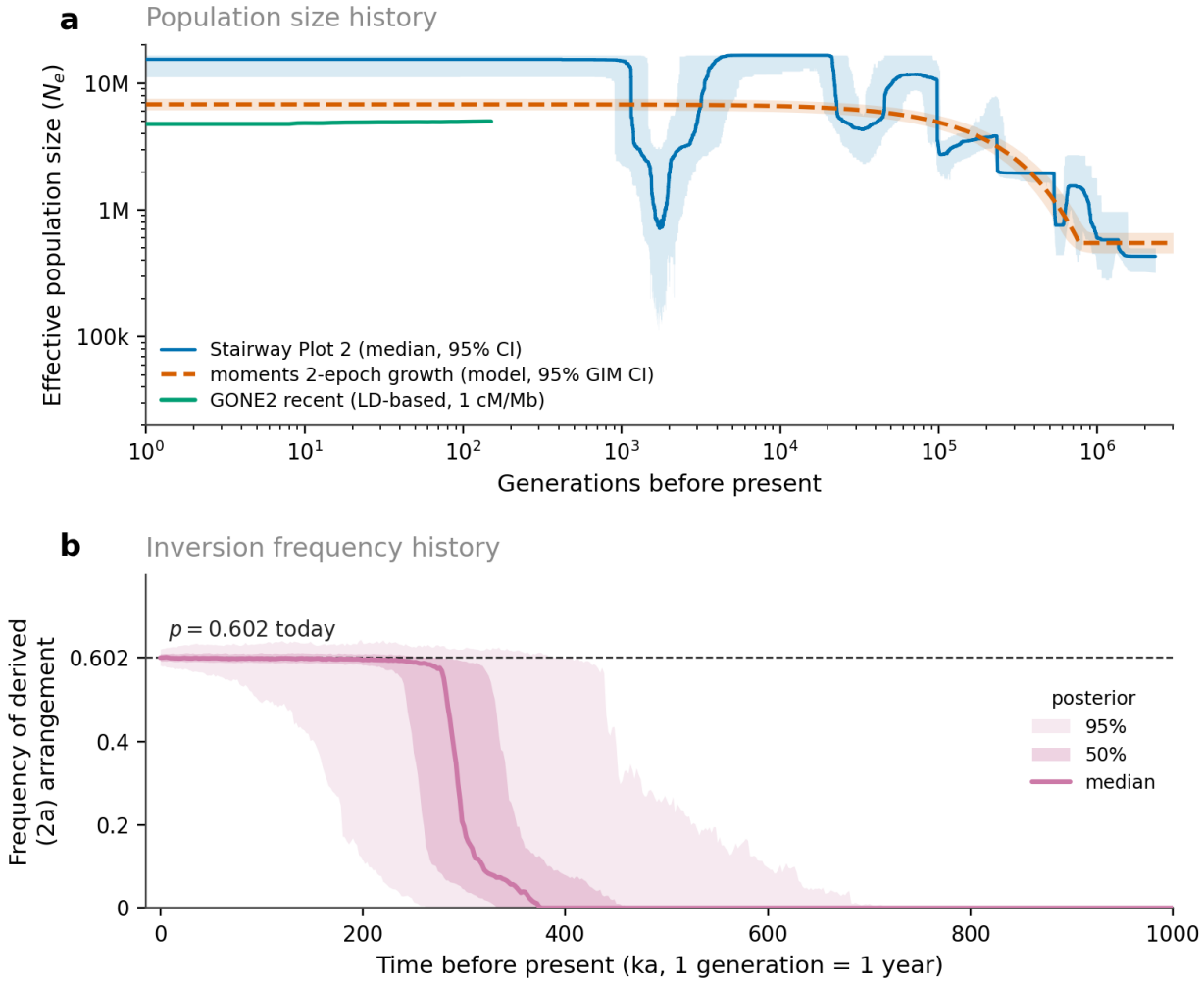


Figure 4: **Demographic history and inversion frequency history. (a)** The effective population size over time is depicted using Stairway Plot 2 (median ±95% CI), alongside the moments 2-epoch growth model with its Godambe (GIM) 95% parameter-CI envelope (expansion 12.4-fold, 95% CI 10.4–14.8, onset 770 ka, 633–935 ka). GONE2 covers the last 150 generations at an assumed uniform 1 cM/Mb without rescaling, and its first four generations, a known edge artifact, are set to the generation-5 value. The Stairway Plot 2 upper limit near 1.67×10^7 is the θ ceiling of that fit. **(b)** Frequency history of the derived (2a) arrangement under the favoured balancing-selection model with gene flux, chosen by ABC-RF with the barrier-aware coalescent simulator msinv, with parameters from neural posterior estimation. The line and bands are the pointwise median, 50% and 95% ranges of 392 trajectories re-simulated from 400 posterior draws. Each draw was re-simulated until its path passed the present-frequency filter, and the eight draws that did not within 50 attempts are omitted, a mild selection on the posterior. Each trajectory rises in a single step whose timing varies among draws, so the width of the bands reflects uncertainty in timing rather than a gradual rise. The barrier formed about 390 ka, and 2a began to rise from a founding frequency near 0.05 towards its equilibrium near 0.60 about 310 ka. The joint posterior, individual trajectories and predictive checks are in Supplementary Figs. S10 and S11.

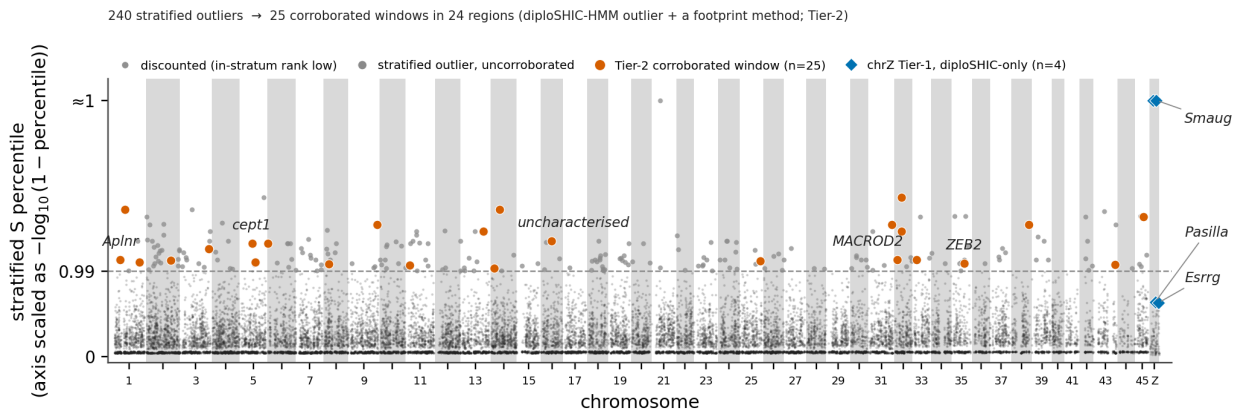


Figure 5: **Genome-wide selective-sweep scan.** The sweep signal across the genome (chromosomes concatenated) is illustrated. The classifier interprets the genome as predominantly linked-selected (∼91% linked-hard or linked-soft, ∼1% neutral, and only a few percent hard or soft). Each window is plotted at the percentile of its diploS/HIC sweep score within its callability and coding-density stratum, and the dashed line marks the top 1% of each stratum (240 stratified outliers, 230 autosomal and 10 on the Z). Stratified outliers that are also RAiSD or SweepFinder2 outliers form the cross-method concordant set and are highlighted (25 windows in 24 regions), with key genes labeled. The background-selection test is not applied to the highlighted set, and the 11 concordant regions that pass it are listed in table 4. Chromosome-Z Tier-1 calls (diamonds, with *Pasilla*, *Smaug*, *Esrrg* labeled) are male-based and diploS/HIC-only (the footprint methods do not cover the Z), thus they cannot be included in the concordance filter. The chromosome-2 inversion does not exhibit a concordant sweep. The complete scan pipeline is detailed in Supplementary Fig. S21.

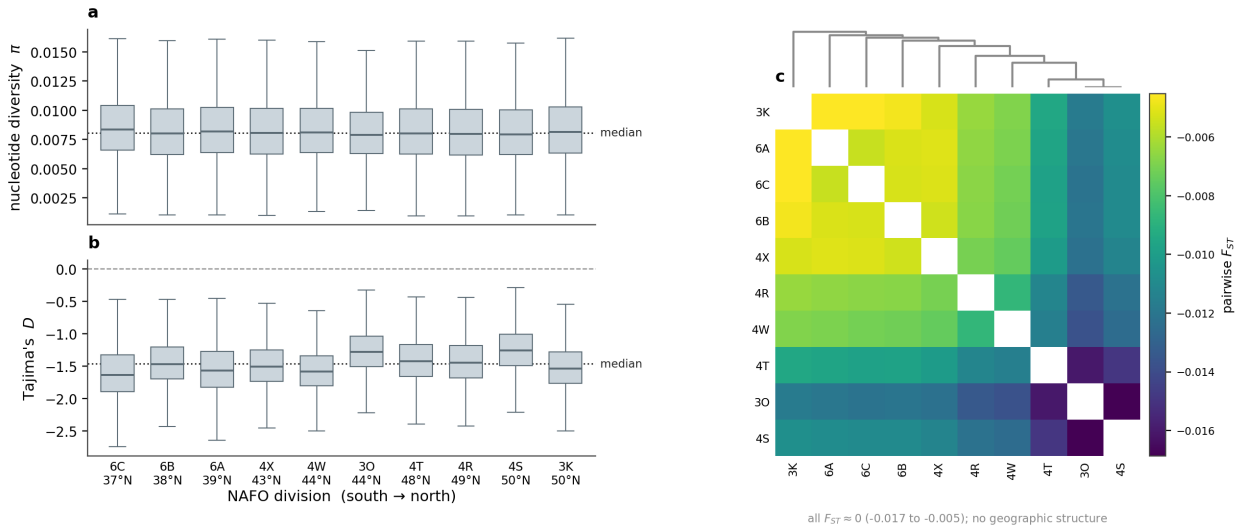


Figure 6: **Diversity is uniform and there is no geographic structure.** **(a)** Nucleotide diversity π and **(b)** Tajima's D per NAFO division (ten of the eleven sampled divisions, as 3N, with a single individual, cannot support per-population estimates), ordered from south to north, and both are flat across latitude (no cline), and D is negative in every population, the signature of strong expansion. **(c)** Pairwise F_{ST} among divisions as a clustered heatmap with dendrogram. Every value is close to zero (-0.017 to -0.005), and the clustering follows sample size rather than geography, so there is no population structure. F_{ST} is the Hudson ratio-of-averages estimator, averaged over the 44 autosomes other than chromosome 2, and its slightly negative values scale with sample size (Supplementary Methods). π and D were estimated from ANGSD genotype likelihoods in 50-kb windows over all 45 autosomes and the Z (males only), on at most 25 individuals per division (all 16, 15 and 23 individuals in 3O, 4S and 4T), so the division medians of D (-1.26 to -1.64) are less negative than the genome-wide -2.07 (Supplementary Methods). Per-chromosome distributions are in Supplementary Fig. S26.

Table 1: **Sample and whole-genome summary.** Diversity statistics are genome-wide from genotype likelihoods, and karyotype counts and the derived-arrangement frequency are for chromosome 2.

Quantity	Value
Species / callset	*Illex illecebrosus*, Baker et al. (2025) whole-genome
Individuals (karyotyped)	618 (of 633 sequenced)
Sex (chrZ coverage)	341 ZZ males / 277 ZO females
Sampling	11 NAFO divisions, ∼37–50°N
Geographic structure	$F_{ST} \approx 0$ (none outside chr2)
Genome-wide π	0.0093
Genome-wide Tajima's D	-2.07 (-2.09 in 50 kb windows)
chr2 karyotypes (2a/2a, 2a/2+, 2+/2+)	222 / 299 / 97
Derived (2a) frequency	0.601 (0.50–0.70 across divisions, non-clinal)
Karyotype F_{ST} (2a/2a vs 2+/2+)	0.362

Table 2: **The chromosome-2 inversion** (I = 2a derived and S = 2+ ancestral). The model was chosen by ABC-RF, and its parameters are NPE posterior medians with 95% credible intervals.

Quantity	Value
Location	chr2:60.54–79.50 Mb (∼18.96 Mb)
Karyotypes (2a/2a, 2a/2+, 2+/2+)	222 / 299 / 97 (99.7% concordant at equal depth)
Derived (2a) frequency p	0.601
Founding frequency p_0	0.05 (0.004–0.10)
Equilibrium frequency p^*	0.603 (0.575–0.707)
Karyotype F_{ST} (2a/2a vs 2+/2+)	0.362 (geographic $F_{ST} \approx 0$)
π_I/π_S (I=2a)	0.719 ± 0.027
d_{xy}/π_S	1.414 ± 0.024
Favoured model	balancing selection with gene flux (ABC-RF $P = 0.83$)
Barrier age t_{inv}	390 ka (260–720 ka), $\propto 1/\mu$ with $\mu = 3 \times 10^{-9}$
Onset of selection	310 ka (190–520 ka)
Selection coefficient	$s > 2.1 \times 10^{-5}$ (95% lower bound only, prior 10^{-6}–10^{-1})
Gene flux	3.9×10^{-7} per site per generation (4×10^{-9} to 6.1×10^{-7})
Gene content	89 gene models, 45 annotated, no GO enrichment ($p = 0.51$)
Near-fixed differences ($\lvert\Delta AF\rvert \geq 0.9$)	5,432 (26 exonic, in 10 genes)

Table 3: **Demographic model** (moments, folded SFS, validated by forward simulation). Ranges are 95% confidence intervals from the Godambe information matrix over 100 chromosome-block bootstraps of the SFS.

Parameter	Value
Ancestral N_e (N_REF)	547,928 (454,382–660,650)
Present N_e (N0)	6,808,096 (6,141,531–7,550,002)
Growth duration (T_GROW)	769,519 generations (633,255–934,536)
Fold expansion	12.4× (10.4–14.8)
Generation time	1 year (annual life cycle, assumed)
Genome-wide π	0.0093
Genome-wide Tajima's D	≈ -2 (nearly all windows)
Mutation rate μ	3×10^{-9} / bp / generation
Recombination (autosomal)	∼0.24 cM/Mb (sex-averaged)

Table 4: **High-confidence selective-sweep candidates**, grouped by biological function and ordered by chromosome, including the Z-chromosome set. Autosomal rows are the 11 background-selection-robust candidates (of 24 concordant regions), and Z rows (marked) are the fine-scale-confirmed sweeps from the males-only scan. Genes are cephalopod orthologs. Class is hard or soft sweep. Full machine-readable tables are in Supplementary Table S8.

Location	Gene / feature	Class
Neural, RNA-regulation & development		
chr6:3.0 Mb	*Rexo1* (RNA exonuclease 1)	hard
chr35:39.0 Mb	*ZEB2* (neural/EMT transcription factor)	hard
Z:20.8 Mb	*Pasilla*/Nova-1 (splicing regulator)	hard (Z)
Z:23.6 Mb	*Smaug*/samd4a (translational repressor)	hard (Z)
Cardiovascular		
chr1:20.3 Mb	*Aplnr* (apelin receptor)	hard
Genome-maintenance & stress		
chr32:9.3 Mb	*MACROD2* (DNA-damage response)	soft
Membrane & lipid		
chr5:38.0 Mb	*cept1* (phospholipid synthesis)	hard
chr1:85.5 Mb	*Cpes* (ceramide phosphoethanolamine synthase) †	hard
Metabolism		
chr25:65.0 Mb	*GALT* †	soft
ECM & adhesion		
chr33:9.0 Mb	*Tinagl1*	hard
Signalling		
chr32:24.1 Mb	GPCR cluster	hard
Z:30.7 Mb	*Esrrg* (estrogen-related receptor)	soft (Z)
Cephalopod-specific novelty		
chr16:35.3 Mb	uncharacterised (*Euprymna* family)	hard
Lower confidence (no gene)		
chr1:35.9 Mb	transposable element ‡	hard

† target reassigned by fine-scale localisation to a neighbouring annotated gene. ‡ peak on an annotated transposable element in a gene desert, 4.5 Mb from the masked chr1:24.0–31.3 Mb block. The window's TE content is typical of the genome (59th percentile), and the signal may be a sweep of the TE insertion or a mapping artifact at the repeat.